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That’s Fit to Print”

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Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00



A volunteer carrying a bucket on Wednesday in an area in Lanton, France, that has been scorched by fires and drought conditions.

SARAH MEYSSONNIER/REUTERS

Saudi Strikes Raise Stakes Of Iran War

This article is by **Raja Abdulrahim, Vivian Nereim, Ismael Naar and Thomas Fuller.**

Airstrikes across the Middle East on Wednesday drew more countries into the war between the United States and Iran, ending a few days of relative calm in the region.

Iran fired missiles at military bases in Jordan and at oil tankers. American and Saudi fighter jets targeted Iranian-linked militias in Iraq. An apparent drone attack also set ablaze two ships, including a U.S.-owned gas storage tanker, at a shipping hub in Egypt.

Since the collapse of a cease-fire between the United States and Iran this month, Iran-linked groups across the region have opened new fronts and reopened old ones, drawing in forces in Saudi Arabia, Iraq, Lebanon and Jordan.

Saudi Arabia’s participation in the attacks on Wednesday amounted to an escalation. Previously, the kingdom had avoided openly becoming a direct combatant in the U.S.-Israeli war on Iran. (The Saudi military had launched some retaliatory strikes on Iran, but those were done in secret, according to senior U.S. officials.)

The Saudi foreign ministry said in a statement Wednesday that the country was not seeking escalation but would respond to aggression.

President Trump on Wednesday described Iran’s assault on U.S. military bases in Jordan as a surprise attack. U.S. Central Command said the Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps, the primary faction in Iran that opposes diplomatic compromise to the war, had launched “multiple ballistic missiles” and that all had been intercepted.

Mr. Trump also suggested that the United States would soon target Iran in response to the apparent drone strike in Egypt. “We’re going to be hitting them very hard,” he told reporters in the Oval Office. “Because it’s our turn to hit ‘em.”

Following the exchanges of fire, the prices of Brent crude, the global benchmark, and West Texas Intermediate, the U.S. benchmark, rose sharply on Wednesday.

This week, Saudi Arabia has faced dozens of drone attacks against its oil facilities. And

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Blistering Summer Pushes Europe to the Brink

By **MARK LANDLER and CHICO HARLAN**

BORDEAUX, France — A dense, yellow-orange pall hung over Bordeaux on Sunday, blotting out the sun and blurring the spires of the cathedral in this French city. A swirl of tiny ash particles stung eyes and stuck in throats. Twenty miles west of town, a mammoth forest fire burned so ferociously that it generated its own weather system.

“We’ve never seen anything like it,” said Roger Peuron, 89, a retired engineer born before World War II, who was driven out of his home by the approaching flames.

Climate Expert Warns, ‘It Will Inevitably Get Worse’

He could have been speaking for millions of people across Europe.

Ravenous fires. Searing heat waves. Freakish storms. The summer of 2026 has already shattered meteorological records in several European countries. On a continent that has weathered centuries of upheaval — ruinous wars, deadly pandemics — it is the weather itself that now has Eu-

rope feeling close to a breaking point.

It has displaced more than 300,000 people in France and Spain, where the largest fires in those countries’ modern history have led to their largest peacetime evacuations, with villages destroyed and hundreds of thousands of acres incinerated. It has left millions more desperate for relief from temperatures that routinely soar above 40 degrees Celsius, or 104 degrees Fahrenheit.

It has forced the cancellation of concerts and festivals, curtailed the final stage of the Tour de France cycling race and closed the Louvre Museum and Eiffel Tower

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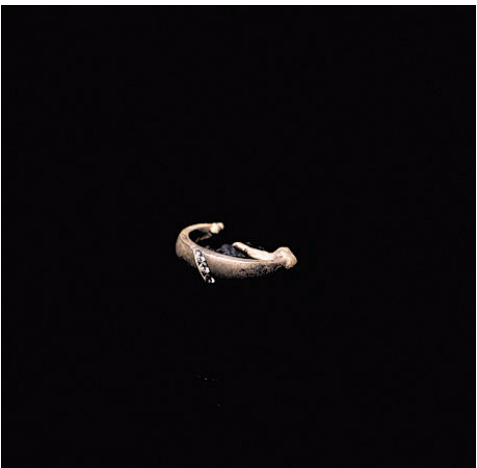
A mother’s gift to her daughter.



A toddler’s favorite pacifier.



His wedding ring, kept in a box with hers.



The glasses he wore every day.



PHOTOGRAPHS BY LAM YIK FEI FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

THE THINGS THEY LEFT BEHIND

Residents of the Hong Kong apartment complex that was devastated in a deadly fire last year were allowed to go back this spring to sift through the ruins of their homes. They returned from the complex, Wang Fuk Court, with objects that are imbued with memories of the loved ones they lost. Page A6.

A Divided Fed Votes to Hold Rates Steady

Pressed to Nip Inflation Amid War and Tariffs

By **COLBY SMITH**

The Federal Reserve on Wednesday kept interest rates unchanged despite growing divisions among policymakers to tackle inflation more directly after five years of overshooting the central bank’s 2 percent target.

The Fed voted 9-3 to maintain rates at 3.5 to 3.75 percent, a level that has been in place since January. The three dissenting members voted for a quarter-point increase.

The divisions underscore the tough spot the Fed and its chairman, Kevin M. Warsh, find themselves in as they grapple with new sources of price pressures that are threatening to compound a complicated and longstanding inflation problem.

Oil prices have whipped around in recent days with the Iran war in a delicate limbo. A deal to end the conflict and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial shipping path for global energy markets, remains distant. President Trump, speaking to reporters on the heels of the Fed’s decision, signaled that the fighting was far from over. He said the United States would mount another round of attacks against Iran. “It’s our turn,” he said, promising to “hit them very hard.”

The war is not the only supply shock the Fed is navigating. Mr. Trump is adding new tariffs, and the labor market is still digesting sweeping immigration restrictions he has put in place.

Officials are also dealing with a booming demand for products tied to the sharp rise in artificial intelligence investment. Supply has yet to catch up, leading to higher prices on items such as semiconductors, computer chips and servers, along with a high demand for electricians and carpenters.

The debate at the Fed centers on how quickly inflation will ease from here as some of these temporary factors fade, and whether rate increases will ultimately be necessary to get inflation to return to target.

Mr. Warsh, who presided over his second meeting as chairman of the central bank, owns the outcome.

Since taking the reins in May from Jerome H. Powell, who is now a Fed governor, Mr. Warsh has staked his reputation on vanquishing inflation. He has been explicit that officials have “no tolerance” for elevated inflation and that evidence of cooling conditions in the latest Consumer Price Index report from June does not amount to “mission accom-

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THE WEATHER

Today, limited sun, humid, showers, high 75. **Tonight**, an evening shower, mostly cloudy, low 68. **Tomorrow**, warmer, clouds and sun, a shower, high 83. Weather map, Page A19.

VOLATILE HEARING AS FAUCI INVOKES 5TH AMENDMENT

SENATE COVID-19 PANEL

Paul Threatens to Hold Him in Contempt as Feud Continues

By **SHERYL GAY STOLBERG**

WASHINGTON — Dr. Anthony S. Fauci refused on Wednesday to answer questions from a Senate committee, repeatedly invoking his constitutional right not to incriminate himself before a panel dominated by hostile Republicans who accused him of causing the coronavirus pandemic and insinuated that he enriched himself while Americans died.

“On the advice of counsel, I respectfully decline to answer based upon my rights under the Fifth Amendment to the Constitution,” Dr. Fauci repeated almost 100 times during a nearly three-hour hearing before the Senate Homeland Security Committee.

The hearing was part Washington theater, part political Rorschach test, highlighting deep



HAIYUN JIANG/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Dr. Anthony S. Fauci on Capitol Hill on Wednesday.

partisan divisions over Dr. Fauci, who spent nearly 40 years as the government’s top infectious disease expert, advising presidents of both parties and generating bipartisan respect until his efforts to curb the spread of Covid-19 turned him into a polarizing figure.

When it ended, Senator Rand Paul, the panel’s chairman, announced that the committee would vote next week on whether to hold Dr. Fauci in contempt of Congress, contending that he was not entitled to Fifth Amendment protection.

“Did his actions lead to the largest man-made plague in history?” Mr. Paul asked as the session concluded. “Are millions dead because of his experiments?” Dr. Fauci left the room stone-faced and flanked by police officers.

Democrats praised Dr. Fauci for his decades of public service and delivered speeches excoriating

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Aiding Repression of Uyghurs, He Says, Left Him Victim, Too

Halfway through a short speech he was giving at the German Bundestag, Zhang Yabo began to choke back tears.

Mr. Zhang had served for nine years as a police officer in Xinjiang, an enforcer in China’s campaign to surveil, detain and indoctrinate that region’s Uyghur population. At the campaign’s height, an estimated one million Uyghurs and other Muslim minorities were held in internment camps.

Tens of thousands of police officers carried out China’s state oppression in Xinjiang, but Mr. Zhang is a rare voice speaking out about it. Standing before German lawmakers and human rights activists in June, he described Xinjiang as a giant pris-

on enclosed by an “ironclad wall.” “That wall imprisoned not only countless innocent Uyghurs,” he said, “but also the souls of those ordered to enforce it.”

Mr. Zhang related the pressure of participating in China’s security apparatus: endless shifts, sleeping in the office and constant fear of punishment. After he requested asylum in Germany last summer, Chinese authorities froze his bank accounts, he said, branded him a traitor and harassed his family.

By the end of the speech, he was sobbing “like a child,” he later told me. He hurried from the room and did not return.

“All the pressure, all the fear, all the emotions that he had carried with him” seemed to

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INTERNATIONAL A4-11

Rescues After Japan’s Quake

Personnel race to free those trapped in collapsed buildings after Tuesday’s 6.8-magnitude earthquake. PAGE A5

Blackouts Spread in Crimea

Ukraine’s attacks have left whole towns in the Russian-occupied region without electricity for days at a time. PAGE A4



NATIONAL A12-19

Trump Seeks Comey Notes

President Trump demanded a summary of the interview conducted by Secret Service agents of the former F.B.I. director James B. Comey. PAGE A15

Broad Rollback of Vaccines

State lawmakers have introduced hundreds of related bills, proposals that offer a window into the modern movement against the shots. PAGE A12

ICE Arrests Rise at Airports

Federal agents are arresting tech workers and others whose visas have expired, including many who have active applications to stay. PAGE A14

BUSINESS B1-6

Tradespeople Sought for A.I.

The future of artificial intelligence depends on finding skilled laborers for physically demanding jobs. PAGE B1

SPORTS B7-10

Finding Purpose Through Pain

A gruesome injury helped Fred Warner, the San Francisco 49ers leader on defense, gain a fresh perspective. PAGE B7

OBITUARIES A20-21

Artist Who Took on Stereotypes

Betye Saar, 99, used dolls and found objects in her assemblage art. PAGE A20

THURSDAY STYLES D1-6

‘The Odyssey’ at Odd Hours

Demand is high for the hit film at the IMAX 70-millimeter theater in New York, even at 2 and 6 a.m. PAGE D1

A Cut Above in SoHo

All around it, luxury boutiques attract high-rollers, but Anonymous Hair Salon won’t empty your bank account. PAGE D6



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Casting a Wide Net

The creative team behind a revival of the musical “Spring Awakening” is using open auditions to fill roles. PAGE C1

Investigation at Interlochen

An inquiry into a school where Jeffrey Epstein was said to have met victims exposed a wider scandal. PAGE C1

OPINION A22-23

Nicholas Kristof

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